

Tip:

Even when you are at a particular place you can use gprs on your phone to look up info on wiki travel

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backpack-newzealand.com for information on backpacking and hiking in New Zealand

CONNECTIONS

work wouldn't begin for another nine days so I had time to kill.

My runaway heart was doing a jig of its own by this time. Tamping down my excitement I approached our editor for leave. After a brief pause he acquiesced. I would get the entire week off — amazing! But wait... there was a snag. He told me to make a note of everything I carried with me. Nope, he wasn't interested in the Brylcreem and shampoo, just the gadgetry. I enquired about his curiosity, but he was vague. I acquiesced, left his bay and got down to what little work I had for the day. During lunch, I made a list and checked off some of the things I'd need for the trip. I decided to shop for the stuff I didn't have that evening after work. At 6.30 pm, I headed off to Croma. I'd get most of the stuff I needed there.

First, I picked up a bunch of Li-ion rechargeable batteries. Eight Sanyo Eneloop AA batteries rated at 2000 mAh with a four-cell charger set me back Rs. 1,250. These batteries are high-drain and the amount of drain if left lying inside any device is negligible. I also picked up four Uniross AAA rechargeable batteries for my GPS unit. Also on the list was a larger memory card for my compact camera, since my 1-GB card was with a friend. My camera, the Canon PowerShot A710IS does not support SDHC memory, so I was limited to a 2-GB card. I spent Rs. 450 on a SanDisk SD card.

I got home to a location dilemma. Some place with mountains like the ones I saw in that wallpaper is where I wanted to be. This holiday was going to be all about being one with nature — the fewer people around the better. Till date I'm not quite sure exactly what made me choose Himachal Pradesh as my destination, but I'm pretty sure it had something to do with the climate there. Rolling hills and sweeping valleys, clean unpolluted environs and some of the most untouched (by man) scenery was another factor. Last, but not the least, the thought of gormandizing mouth-watering momos and seeing my breath vapour as I sipped piping hot coffee was the clincher. Himachal it was!

Destination confirmed, I decided to fly to Delhi and from there catch a bus to Shimla. I visited www.makemytrip.com and checked out the availability and cost of air tickets for Delhi on a Saturday. I booked myself on an afternoon flight and also booked my return from Delhi for the Saturday after next. That way I'd have Sunday to unpack and rest when I got back. After checking up on the availability of buses to Shimla and finding many options I leaned back for a moment of quiet contemplation — the calm before the storm in retrospect.



Nikon D60 — The entry-level king amongst DSLRs

Clothes... I'd need to pack warm. My Levis. were in for sure. My hiking boots I'd wear — these darn things take up a third of my duffel bag, so they're better off on my feet at all times. And then the thunderbolt struck — which of my geeky possessions would I be able to carry with me and which would I be forced to part with for a whole week? From experience this is the most painful part of every vacation I take — the hours I spend agonizing over which of my lovesies I'll have to live without.

I was immediately depressed as I realised I would not be able to take as much as I wanted. I'd have to live without the NVIDIA GTX 285 that I had taken home from the office for a whole week! No games. No beautiful 24-inch LCD. Damn!

These thoughts alone were nearly enough for me to irrationally consider cancelling my flight reservations — I kid you not. In anguish, I reached for a cola from my fridge and plonked on to the sofa, taking a long, hard swig from the can as my thoughts whirled. Rationality slowly returned. I decided to pack all my gadgets first and use the remaining space for the necessary evils such as toiletries, towel and clothing.

An action-plan in place, I checked my watch and decided to get a few things ready before hitting the sack. I unpacked my Nikon D60. This beast has a 10.2 megapixel CCD sensor and features a vibration-based dust cleaning system. The beauty of the D60 is that whether you're a pro or a

novice, you can get quality results and although its low-light performance isn't class leading, its pretty good and very newbie friendly. At Rs. 35,000 (with its default lens) this camera comes highly recommended. Canon fans will want to look at the EOS 400D. Priced almost identically to the Nikon D60, this camera offers similar quality, although I find its menu system to be unnecessarily complex. Canon's lenses are also much costlier. I removed my camera's battery pack and set it to charge. Later, I would charge the spare battery pack I always carry. I also



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